especially towards the Taliban government in Afghanistan when it continued to shelter and fund the Tehrik-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP), a rebel group pushing for an Islamic emirate in Pakistan. In late 2023, Munir expelled more than 150,000 Afghan refugees in Pakistan, putting him in direct confrontation with the ruling Taliban in Afghanistan.

And while maintaining a pragmatic relationship with Iran, Munir did not hesitate to fire a missile into Iranian territory following Teheran's drone strike on an Iranian resistance group operating out of Pakistan. Munir has also cracked down severely on the Baloch rebel groups clamouring for an independent Balochistan. It's a different matter that they have regrouped and recently struck back with vengeance, undermining the Pakistani army's take-no-prisoners strategy. Munir has repeatedly blamed India for instigating and/or backing both the Baloch and the TTP rebels. Many experts in Pakistan offer it as the rationale for the Pahalgam attack. For India, these are clear signs that Munir is an unrelenting foe, one who is not afraid to retaliate even when the cards seem stacked against him.

The Jihadi Turn

There are other causes for concern for India. Since Munir took over as army chief, he has become more strident with his brand of religious nationalism. He has recast the army's role not just as defender of Pakistan's territorial integrity and sovereignty but also as the guardian of its ideological frontiers. Addressing a tribal *jirga* (council) in Peshawar in August 2023, Munir had declared, "No power in the world can harm Pakistan. We are waging *jihad* (holy war) in the path of Allah and success will be ours. The Pakistan army's objective and principle is to be *shahid* (martyr) or *ghazi* (one who takes part in *jihad*)." His proclamation earned him the sobriquet of 'Jihadi General'.

What spooked Indian experts, however, was Munir's comments at an Overseas Pakistanis Convention on April 16, six days before the Pahalgam outrage, where he reiterated the two-nation theory but more crudely, highlighting the "stark difference between Hindus and Muslims" in a tone more extreme than even Zia's declamations. As T.C.A. Raghavan, a former Indian High Commissioner to Pakistan, points out, "Munir's ideological position on India remains the standard two-nation theory and he believes it is the Pakistan army that stands between the nation and its total domination by India. He thinks Kashmir is the unfinished agenda of the creation of Pakistan and that Pakistan is the victim of great injustice and it is the responsibility of the Pakistan army to correct that."

Experts believe that there are several reasons why Munir greenlit the Pahalgam attacks. Among them is domestic turmoil, including the failure to manage internal divisions and



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rebellions that have dented the army's image. Feeling the heat, Munir brought India into the equation in order to rally the masses behind him.

The Pakistani general may have already succeeded in that endeavour, especially after India announced the suspension of the IWT, an act that threatens to impact water supply to the most populous and politically powerful provinces of Punjab and Sindh. "Munir wants to consolidate his power and emerge as the Supreme Leader," says Bisaria. "With the liberal and urban guys turning against him, he wants to win over the bulk of the right-wing establishment." A Pakistani expert, who does not want to be named, agrees. "There are two Pakistans," he says. "There is a Jihadi Pakistan which is all about creating a Pakistani identity based on an irreconcilable antipathy towards India. And there is a non-Jihadi Pakistan that believes it can exist as a federation and have normal relations with Afghanistan, Iran, India and China to do trade. Munir is appealing to the Jihadi Pakistan, which is around 60 per cent of the population. So, India needs to win over the non-Jihadi constituency."